removed from distribution in the GDR.15 The journal had published a damning article on the Molotov-Ribbentrop Pact of 1939 and Stalin's 'mistakes, failures and crimes' before and during the Second World War. The article asserted Stalin 'had been a mere puppet of Hitler', and Germany's communists were culpable in the rise of Hitler by not 'joining together with Social Democrats to stop him'. The decisive factor for the outburst of anger from the SED leadership, however, was Sputnik's question: 'Would there have been Hitler without Stalin?' This was answered with a plausible hypothesis: if the communists had allied themselves with the Social Democrats in Germany before 1933 in the fight against the Nazis, Hitler would not have won the Reichstag elections and history would most likely have turned out differently.16

As a veteran of the fight against Nazism, Honecker seethed with rage, calling the article not only stupid but despicable. In a short-fused response, Neues Deutschland declared Soviet history and the history of the German Communist Party had been distorted by Sputnik. 'The magazine – and we say this openly – defames German communists … distorted visions of Soviet history are incompatible with our friendship with the Soviet Union.'17 Although unsigned, Honecker personally wrote the Neues Deutschland text (distributed by the ADN news agency to the media).18 The open-ended Sputnik ban marked the first time a Soviet magazine had been prohibited in the GDR; simultaneously, five Soviet feature films – all with anti-Stalinist themes – were removed from the national cinema circuit. The Sputnik decision proved hugely important, not only as a mechanism for open dispute between East Berlin and Moscow but also for dissent within the GDR.19

In the ensuing uproar, the SED Central Committee, the FDJ, the Society for German-Soviet Friendship and newspaper offices, received the drumbeat of criticism as thousands of petitions and complaints arrived from companies, universities, schools and individuals demanding Sputnik's return.20

Coupled with disenchantment with the economic decline and ecological problems, the Sputnik action also led to an unprecedented wave of resignations from the SED. An investigation noted dissatisfaction at the